

Augustine Letters 400

Ep. 43, salutation and § 1 — to the Donatist laymen of Cirta (c. 396/7; CSEL 34.2, pp. 85–86)

43.

TO HIS MOST BELOVED LORDS AND RIGHTLY-TO-BE-PRAISED BROTHERS GLORIUS, ELEUSIUS, THE FELIXES, GRAMMATICUS, AND THE OTHERS TO WHOM THIS IS WELCOME, AUGUSTINE.

1. The apostle Paul did indeed say: *A heretical man, after one correction, avoid, knowing that such a one is subverted and sins and is condemned by his own judgment.* But those who defend their opinion, however false and perverse, with no obstinate animosity — especially one which they did not beget by the audacity of their own presumption, but received from parents who were themselves led astray and fallen into error — and who moreover seek the truth with cautious concern, ready to be set right once they have found it: these are by no means to be counted among the heretics. Unless I believed you to be such, I would perhaps send you no letter at all; yet just as we advise that even the heretic — swollen with however hateful a pride and mad with the obstinacy of evil contentiousness — is to be shunned, lest he deceive the weak and the little ones, so we do not refuse that he be corrected by whatever means we can. Hence it came about that we wrote even to certain leading men of the Donatists — not communicatory letters, which for a long time now, because of their perversity, they do not accept from the Catholic unity that is spread throughout the whole world, but private ones of the kind we are permitted to use even toward pagans. And these letters, though they read them at some point, [[p. 86]] they were either unwilling to answer, or — as is more readily believed — unable. In this it seemed to us that we had sufficiently fulfilled the duty of charity, which the Holy Spirit teaches us we owe not only to our own but to all, when he says to us through the apostle: *But may the Lord make you increase and abound in charity toward one another and toward all.* He also admonishes in another place that those who think otherwise are to be corrected with moderation: *Lest perhaps,* he says, *God grant them repentance to acknowledge the truth, and they recover themselves from the snares of the devil, by whom they are held captive at his will.*

Ep. 43, §§ 2–3 — the Caecilian case stated (pp. 86–87)

2. I have said these things by way of preface, lest anyone suppose that I have sent you writings more impudently than prudently, and have wished in this way to treat with you about the business of your soul, because you are not of our communion — whereas, nonetheless, if I were writing to you something about the business of an estate or about settling some money-dispute, no one perhaps would find fault. So dear is this world to men, and they have become worthless to themselves. This letter, therefore, will be for me

a witness for my defense at the judgment of God, who knows with what intention I have acted, and who said: *Blessed are the peacemakers, for they shall be called the sons of God.*

3. So then, that you may deign to remember: when we were in your city and were discussing with you certain matters concerning the communion of Christian unity, certain acts were produced by your party, in which it was read out that some seventy bishops had condemned Caecilian — once a bishop of our communion, of the church of Carthage — together with his colleagues and ordainers. There too the case of Felix of Aptungi was aired much more [[p. 87]] invidiously and reproachfully than the rest. When all these had been read through, we replied that it was not to be wondered at if men who at that time made that schism thought — not without the drawing-up of records — that those against whom they had been stirred up by rivals and reprobates ought to be rashly condemned in absence, their case unheard; but that we had other ecclesiastical acts, in which Secundus of Tigisis, who then held the primacy in Numidia, left *traditores* who were present and confessed to be judged by God, and permitted them to remain in their episcopal sees, just as they were — men whose names are counted among the condemners of Caecilian — although Secundus himself held the presidency of that same council, where he condemned, by their sentences, absent men as though *traditores*, whom, present and confessing, he had pardoned.

Ep. 43, §§ 7–9 (ch. III) — the principate of the apostolic chair, and the tractatoria mechanism (pp. 89–92)

7. For if the thought of peace dwelt in his heart, he would not afterward at Carthage have condemned, on the charge of *traditio*, men whom no one had convicted while they were absent before him — those very men whom, when present [[p. 90]] and confessing, he had left to God's judgment. For he ought to have feared all the more that the peace of unity should be violated, the more that Carthage was a city large and illustrious, from which the evil that had arisen there might pour itself out over the whole body of Africa as from a head. It was also near to the regions overseas and renowned by a most celebrated report. And so it had a bishop of no ordinary authority, one who could disregard the conspiring multitude of his enemies, seeing that he was joined by communicatory letters both to the Roman church — in which the principate of the apostolic chair has always flourished — and to the other lands from which the gospel came to Africa itself, where he would be ready to plead his case, should his adversaries try to alienate those churches from him. Since, therefore, he was unwilling to come to the lodging of colleagues whom he perceived, or suspected, or (as they themselves assert) pretended, to have been made hostile by his enemies against the truth of his case, Secundus, all the more, had he wished to be a guardian of true peace, ought to have taken care that men not be condemned in absence who were entirely unwilling to be present at their judgment. For it was not a matter of presbyters or deacons or clerics of lower rank, but of colleagues — men who could reserve their case intact for the judgment of other colleagues, especially of the apostolic churches, where the sentences pronounced against them in their absence would have no force whatever, since it was not that they first approached that judgment and afterward deserted it, but that, always holding it suspect, they were never willing to approach it.

8. This matter ought above all to have troubled Secundus, who was then primate, if he was presiding over the council for this purpose, that he might take counsel for peace; for perhaps he might easily have restrained and curbed the mouths raging against the absent, and calmed them, [[p. 91]] had he said: 'You see, brothers, that after so great a

devastation of persecution, peace has by God's mercy been granted us by the princes of the age; we Christians and bishops ought not to break the Christian unity which now no pagan enemy persecutes. Therefore either let us leave to God the judge all these cases which the disaster of a most turbulent time has inflicted upon the Church, or, if there are any among you who know the crimes of these men so surely that they can readily prove them and convict them when they deny, and who dread to communicate with such men — let these go to our brothers and colleagues, the bishops of the churches overseas, and there first lodge complaint of these men's deeds and defiance, in that, guilty in their own conscience, they were unwilling to come to the judgment of their African colleagues; that from there it may be announced to them, that they should come and answer the charges there. But if they do not do so, there too their depravity and perversity will become known, and, a circular letter (*tractatoria*) having been sent out under their name through the whole world, wherever the Church of Christ is now spread, communion with them will be cut off by all the churches, lest any error arise in the see of the church of Carthage. Then at last, secure, we shall ordain another bishop for the people of Carthage, when these men have been separated by the whole Church — lest perhaps, when another has just been ordained, he not be granted communion by the church overseas, because the former will not be seen as deposed from his office, since report has already made him famous once ordained and has caused communicatory letters to travel to him; and so a great scandal of schism arise in the unity of Christ, in these now-peaceful times, while we wish to rush our sentences headlong, and dare to set up another altar not against Caecilian but against [[p. 92]] the whole world which through ignorance communicates with him.'

9. Whoever, ungoverned, had refused to obey this counsel, so sound and right — what would he have been going to do, or how would he have condemned any of the absent colleagues, when he did not have the acts of the council in his power, the primate speaking against it? And if so great a sedition should arise even against the first see, that some now wished to condemn those whom he wished to be deferred, how much better to be at odds with such men, who were plotting restless and unpeaceful things, than with the communion of the whole world! But because there were no charges that could be proved against Caecilian and his ordainers before a court overseas, therefore neither, before they pronounced sentences against him, were they willing to defer, nor, after they had pronounced them, to press on persistently with this — that it be brought to the knowledge of the churches overseas which *traditores*, condemned in Africa, they ought to shun communion with; because, had they tried to do this, Caecilian and the rest would be present to support themselves and would clear their case, before the ecclesiastical judges overseas, by the most careful examination against their lying accusers.

Ep. 43, §§ 19–20 (ch. VII) — the whole world does not communicate with them (pp. 100–102)

19. But after they had learned by the facts themselves that the communion of the whole world persevered with Caecilian, and that communicatory letters were sent to him from the churches over[[p. 101]]seas — and not to that man whom they had wickedly ordained — they were ashamed to keep silent forever, since it could be objected against them: why did they allow a Church that through so many nations knew nothing of the matter to communicate with the condemned, and why did they cut themselves off from the communion of the innocent world, when by their silence they let the bishop whom they had ordained for the Carthaginians go without communion from the whole world? They chose, so it is said, to conduct their case against Caecilian before the churches overseas on two counts, ready for either outcome: that, if by any cunning of false accusation they could convict him, they might sate their desire to the full; but if they could not, they

would indeed persist in the same perversity, yet now, as though they had something to say, that they had suffered bad judges — which is the cry of all bad litigants, even when they have been overcome by the most manifest truth — as though it could not be said to them, and most justly said: ‘Come, let us suppose that those bishops who judged at Rome were not good judges.’ There still remained a plenary council of the universal Church, where the case could be tried even with the judges themselves, so that, if they were convicted of having judged badly, their sentences might be annulled. Whether they did this, let them prove; for we easily prove that it was not done, from the fact that the whole world does not communicate with them; or, if it was done, there too they were beaten, as their very separation makes plain.

20. But what they did afterward is shown quite sufficiently by the emperor’s letters. For those ecclesiastical judges, bishops of such great authority, by whose verdict both Caecilian’s innocence and their own wickedness had been declared, they dared to accuse not before other colleagues but before the emperor, alleging that they had judged badly. He granted another court, at Arles, of other bishops of course — not because it was now necessary, but yielding to their perversities [[p. 102]] and desiring in every way to check so great an impudence. For a Christian emperor did not dare so to take up their tumultuous and deceitful complaints as himself to sit in judgment over the judgment of the bishops who had presided at Rome, but gave, as I said, other bishops. From whom, nonetheless, they preferred to appeal again to the emperor himself. In which matter you have heard how he detests them. And would that they had at least, by his very judgment, put an end to their utterly insane animosities! and that, as he himself yielded to them — judging that case after the bishops, though he would afterward seek pardon of the holy prelates, provided only that they might have nothing further to say if they did not obey the sentence of the one to whom they themselves had appealed — so they too might at some time have yielded to the truth! For he ordered that the parties should meet at Rome to plead the case. And when Caecilian, for some reason, had not come there, at their instance he directed that they should follow to Milan. Then some of them began to withdraw themselves, perhaps indignant that Constantine had not imitated them, so as at once and swiftly to condemn Caecilian in absence. When the provident emperor learned this, he had the rest kept under guard by his officers and brought to Milan. And when Caecilian too had come there, he produced him also, as he wrote; and, the case having been examined — with what diligence, what caution, what foresight his letters make plain — he judged Caecilian entirely innocent and them utterly wicked.

Ep. 44, §§ 5–6 (ch. III) — succession kept through the whole world (pp. 113–114)

5. But nonetheless, setting aside that doubtful question, I asked how these men had justly separated themselves from the innocence of the rest of the Christians who, keeping throughout the whole world the order of succession, established in the most ancient churches, were utterly ignorant of who the *traditores* in Africa had been, and who certainly could communicate only with those whom they heard to be seated in episcopal sees. He answered that the churches of the regions overseas remained innocent only so long as they had not consented to the blood of those whom he claimed had endured the Macarian persecution. Here I could indeed have said that the innocence of the churches overseas could not be contaminated even by the odium of the Macarian time, since it could in no way be proved that, with those men as authors, it had done what it did; but I preferred to inquire by the shorter route: whether, if the churches overseas lost their

innocence from the time they were said to have consented to the savagery of Macarius, it could at least be proved that down to those times the Donatists had remained in unity with the eastern churches and the rest of the world's regions.

6. Then he produced a certain volume, in which he wished to show that the Council of Serdica had sent a letter to the African bishops who were of Donatus's communion. When it was read, we heard the name of Donatus among the other bishops to whom they had written. And so we began to demand that it be shown whether this was the Donatus after whose party these men are named; for it could be that they had written to some Donatus who was a bishop of another heresy, especially since in those names there was not even a mention of Africa; how then could he prove that Donatus was to be taken, under that name, as a bishop of Donatus's party, [[p. 114]] when he could not prove even this — whether that letter had been sent specifically to the bishops of the African churches? For although the name Donatus is commonly African, it would nevertheless not be contrary to the truth that either someone of those regions was called by an African name, or that some African was appointed bishop in those regions. For we find in them neither a day nor a consul, so that, the dates at least being considered, something certain might come to light. Indeed, since we had at some point heard that the Arians, when they had fallen out with the Catholic communion, had tried to ally the Donatists to themselves in Africa, brother Alypius suggested this very thing in my ear. Then, taking up the volume itself and examining the decrees of that council, I read that Athanasius, the Catholic bishop of Alexandria, whose conflict of most fierce disputations against the Arians stood out above all, and Julius, no less Catholic bishop of the Roman church, had been condemned by that Council of Serdica. Whence it was established for us that it had been a council of Arians, whom these Catholic bishops most vehemently resisted. And so, for a still more careful examination of the dates, we wished to take the volume itself and carry it off with us. He refused to give it, saying that we had it there whenever we wished to examine anything in it. I also asked that he permit it to be marked by my own hand — fearing, I confess, that if perhaps, when the case required and it had to be produced, another might be brought forward in its place. This too he refused.

Ep. 53, to Generosus, complete — the succession from Peter, and the traditor-rider (c. 400; pp. 152–158)

53.

TO HIS MOST BELOVED AND HONORABLE BROTHER GENEROSUS,
FORTUNATUS, ALYPIUS, AND AUGUSTINE, GREETING IN THE LORD.

1. Since you wished us to know the letter which a presbyter of the Donatists sent to you — although you too laughed at it with a Catholic mind — nevertheless, so that you may rather take counsel for him, if he is not hopelessly out of his senses, we ask that you deliver to him this reply. For he wrote that an angel had commanded him to lay before you the “order of Christianity” of your city — whereas you hold a Christianity not of your city only, nor only of Africa or of the Africans, but of the whole world, which has been and is announced to all nations. Whence it is too little that they are not ashamed to be cut off, nor come to their own aid, so as, while they can, to return to the root, unless they also try to cut off others along with themselves and consign them, like dry wood, to the fire. Therefore, if an angel had stood by you yourself — the one whom that man, as we judge, feigns with crafty vanity to have stood by him on your account — and had said to you these very things which that man says he lays before you by the angel's command, you would have to be mindful of the apostolic sentence which says: *Even if we, or an*

angel from heaven, should preach to you a gospel beyond that which we have preached to you, let him be anathema. For it has been announced to you by the voice of the Lord Jesus Christ himself, that *his gospel shall be announced to all nations, and then shall be the end*; it has been announced to you by the prophetic and apostolic writings, that the promises were spoken to Abraham and to his seed, [[p. 153]] which is Christ, when God said to him: *In your seed shall all nations be blessed*. Therefore, to you who hold these promises, if an angel from heaven should say: ‘Abandon the Christianity of the whole world and hold to the party of Donatus, whose order is set out for you in the letter of the bishop of your city,’ he would deserve to be anathema, because he would be trying to cut you off from the whole and thrust you into a part and estrange you from the promises of God.

2. For if the order of bishops succeeding one another is to be considered, how much more surely and truly wholesomely do we count from Peter himself, to whom, as bearing the figure of the whole Church, the Lord said: *Upon this rock I will build my Church, and the gates of hell shall not prevail against it*. For to Peter succeeded Linus, to Linus Clement, to Clement Anacletus, to Anacletus Evaristus, to Evaristus Sixtus, to Sixtus Telesphorus, to Telesphorus Hyginus, to Hyginus Anicetus, to Anicetus Pius, to Pius Soter, to Soter Alexander, to Alexander Victor, to Victor Zephyrinus, to Zephyrinus Calistus, to Calistus Urbanus, to Urbanus Pontianus, to Pontianus Antherus, to Antherus Fabianus, to Fabianus Cornelius, to Cornelius Lucius, to Lucius Stephanus, to Stephanus Sixtus, to Sixtus Dionysius, to Dionysius Felix, to Felix Eutychianus, to Eutychianus Gaius, to Gaius Marcellus, to Marcellus Eusebius, to Eusebius [[p. 154]] Melchiades, to Melchiades Silvester, to Silvester Marcus, to Marcus Julius, to Julius Liberius, to Liberius Damasus, to Damasus Siricius, to Siricius Anastasius. In this order of succession no Donatist bishop is found. But they sent, from across the way, one ordained out of Africa, who, presiding over a few Africans in the city of Rome, propagated the name of the “Montenses” or “Cutzupitae.”

3. But into that order of bishops which runs from Peter himself down to Anastasius, who now sits in the same chair, even if some *traditor* had crept in unnoticed through those times, it would prejudice nothing for the Church and for innocent Christians — for whom the Lord, providing in advance, says concerning evil superiors: *What they say, do; but what they do, do not do; for they say and do not do* — so that the hope of the faithful may be sure, which, placed not in man but in the Lord, is never scattered by the storm of a sacrilegious schism, as those men have been scattered, who read in the sacred books the churches to which the apostles wrote, and yet have no bishop among them. And what is more perverse and insane than for their readers, as they read those very letters, to say ‘Peace be with you,’ and yet to be separated from the peace of those churches to which those very letters were written?

4. But lest he flatter himself even about the “Constantinian” — that is, about the order of bishops of your city — read to him the acts drawn up before Munatius Felix, perpetual flamen, then curator [[p. 155]] of that same city of yours, in the consulship of Diocletian for the eighth time and Maximian for the seventh, on the eleventh day before the Kalends of June, by which it was clearly established that Bishop Paulus handed over the sacred books in such a way that Silvanus was then his subdeacon and handed them over together with him, bringing out the dominical instruments — even those which had been carefully hidden — a silver casket and a silver lamp, so that a certain Victor said to him: ‘You would have been a dead man if you had not found them.’ This Silvanus — a most manifest *traditor* — that man commemorates as a great figure in the letter he wrote to you, as having then been ordained bishop by Secundus of Tigisis, bishop of the first see. Let their proud tongue therefore be still, and let it acknowledge its own crimes, lest, raving, it speak of the crimes of others. Read to him also, if he is willing, the

ecclesiastical acts of the same Secundus of Tigisis, held in the house of Urbanus Donatus, where he dismissed confessed *traditores* to God as judge — Donatus of Masculi, Marinus of Aquae Tibilitanae, Donatus of Calama — with which confessed *traditores* he ordained for them, as bishop, the aforesaid *traditor* Silvanus. Read to him the acts before Zenophilus the consular, where a certain deacon Nundinarius, angry with Silvanus because he had been excommunicated by him, laid bare all these things before the courts — matters which, by sure documents and by the answers of witnesses and by the reading of the acts and of many letters, were established clearer than light.

5. There are many other things which you may read to him, if he is willing not to act contentiously but to listen prudently: the petition of the Donatists to Constantine, that for the settling of the case itself between the African bishops he should send judges, bishops, from Gaul; also the letters of the same emperor, where he sent bishops to the city of [[p. 156]] Rome; the acts too drawn up in the city of Rome, where by the bishops whom he had sent the case was examined and discussed; and likewise other letters, where the aforesaid emperor declares that they had complained before him about the judgment of their own colleagues — that is, of the bishops whom he had sent to the city of Rome; where he also willed that other bishops should judge at Arles; where these men appealed even from their judgment to the same emperor; where at last he himself examined the case between the parties; where he most vehemently detests them as having been overcome by Caecilian's innocence. All of which, if he is willing, he will hear, and will fall silent, and will cease to lie in wait against the truth.

6. And yet we presume not so much upon these documents as upon the holy Scriptures, where the inheritance of Christ is promised, unto the ends of the earth, in all nations. Whence these men, separated by a wicked schism, hurl their charges against the chaff of the Lord's harvest, which of necessity must be tolerated, mixed in, until the end, until at the last judgment the whole threshing-floor is winnowed. Whence it is plain that these charges, whether true or false, do not pertain to the Lord's grain, which must grow throughout the whole field — that is, this world — until the end of the age, as it is not a false angel in this man's error but the Lord in the gospel who speaks. And therefore, upon the innocent Christians who throughout the whole world are mixed in with evil Christians as if with their own chaff or tares, while these wretched Donatists hurl many false and empty charges, God has deservedly requited it, that they should condemn, in their universal council, the Maximianists at Carthage — their own schismatics, condemners of Primianus, baptizers apart from Primianus, [[p. 157]] rebaptizers after Primianus — and that, out of their number, after no small time, they should receive certain men in the honors of their episcopate — Felicianus of Musti and Praetextatus of Assuras, Optatus Gildonianus compelling it — together with all whom, being condemned, they had baptized outside. But if by those men whom with their own mouth they condemned as criminal and sacrilegious, and whom they compared to those first schismatics whom the earth swallowed alive, they are not defiled, when they communicate with them received back into their own honor — then let them at some time wake up and consider with what blindness and what insanity they say that the whole world is defiled by the unknown crimes of Africans, and that the inheritance of Christ, which was promised and displayed in all nations, has been wiped out by the sins of Africans through the contagion of communication — since they do not wish themselves to be seen as wiped out and defiled, while they communicate with those whose crimes they judged when known.

7. Wherefore, since the apostle Paul says again that *Satan himself transforms himself into an angel of light*, whence it is no wonder if *his ministers transform themselves as ministers of righteousness* — if this man truly saw some angel, a messenger of error and desiring to separate Christians from the Catholic unity, then he himself has suffered an angel of Satan transforming himself as an angel of light. But if he lies and saw no such

thing, then he himself is a minister of Satan transforming himself as a minister of righteousness. And yet, considering all these things, if he is unwilling to be too perverse and obstinate, he will be able to be freed from all seduction, whether another's or his own. For we have addressed him, through the occasion of you, without any hatred, keeping toward him what the apostle says: *But the servant of the Lord ought not to [[p. 158]] quarrel, but to be gentle toward all, teachable, patient, correcting with moderation those who think otherwise, lest perhaps God grant them repentance to acknowledge the truth, and they recover themselves from the snares of the devil, by whom they are held captive at his will.* If, therefore, we have said anything harshly, let him recognize that it avails not toward the bitterness of dissension but toward the correction of love. May you live safe in Christ, most beloved and honorable brother. Amen.

Ep. 54, § 1 — what the universal Church observes (pp. 158–160)

54.

TO THE INQUIRIES OF JANUARIUS, BOOK ONE.

TO HIS MOST BELOVED SON JANUARIUS, AUGUSTINE, GREETING IN THE LORD.

1. To the things you have asked me, I would prefer first to know what you yourself, if asked, would answer; for so, by either approving or [[p. 159]] correcting your answers, I could reply much more briefly, and could most easily either confirm you or correct you. This indeed, as I said, I would prefer. But nevertheless, so as to reply now, I have preferred to make a longer discourse rather than a longer delay. First, therefore, I want you to hold what is the head of this discussion: that our Lord Jesus Christ, as he himself says in the gospel, has subjected us *to his gentle yoke and to a light burden*. Whence he has bound together the society of the new people by sacraments very few in number, very easy in observance, most excellent in signification — such as baptism consecrated in the name of the Trinity, the communion of his body and blood, and whatever else is commended in the canonical Scriptures, except those things which burdened the servitude of the old people in keeping with the disposition of their heart and with the prophetic time, things which are also read in the five books of Moses. But those things which we keep not as written but as handed down — which indeed are observed throughout the whole world — are given to be understood as retained because commended and established either by the apostles themselves or by plenary councils, whose authority in the Church is most salutary: as that the Lord's passion and resurrection and ascension into [[p. 160]] heaven, and the coming of the Holy Spirit from heaven, are celebrated with an annual solemnity, and whatever else of this kind occurs that is observed by the universal Church, wherever it spreads itself.

Ep. 89, §§ 4–5 — the secure Church places no hope in man (c. 406; pp. 421–423)

4. But let these be reckoned human judgments, and let it be said that they could be circumvented and deceived, or even corrupted. Why, then, is the Christian world still accused and defamed with I know not what crimes of *traditores* — the world which certainly neither could nor ought to have trusted any but chosen judges rather than

defeated litigants? Those judges have their case before God, whether good or bad; what did the Church spread through the whole world do — the Church which for no other reason is judged by these men to be rebaptized, except that in that case, in which it could not judge what was true, it thought it should trust those who were able to judge rather than those who, unconquered, did not yield? O great crime of all the nations, which God promised should be blessed in the seed of Abraham, and, as he promised, has displayed! When with one voice they said, ‘Why do you wish to rebaptize us?’, it is answered them: ‘Because you do not know who were [[p. 422]] the *traditores* of the holy books in Africa, and in that which you did not know you chose to trust judges rather than accusers.’ If another’s crime does not burden anyone, what does it concern the world, what someone committed in Africa? If an unknown crime does not burden anyone, whence could the world have known either the crime of the judges or of the accused? Judge, you who have a heart. Is this the heretical justice — that, because the world does not condemn an unknown crime, the party of Donatus should condemn the world unheard? But surely it suffices for the world to hold the promises of God and to see fulfilled in itself what the prophets sang so long before, and to recognize in the same Scriptures the Church, where its king too, Christ, is recognized. For where such things about Christ were foretold as we read fulfilled in the gospel, there such things were foretold about the Church as we now discern being fulfilled throughout the whole world.

5. Unless perhaps it will trouble any of the prudent, what they are accustomed to say about baptism — that the baptism of Christ is true only then, when it is given by a righteous man — whereas on this point too the world holds the most evident and evangelical truth, where John says: *He who sent me to baptize in water, he himself said to me: ‘Upon whom you shall see the Spirit descending like a dove and remaining upon him, he it is who baptizes in the Holy Spirit.’* Whence the secure Church places no hope in man, lest it fall into that sentence in which it is written: *Cursed is everyone who places his hope in man*, but places its hope in Christ, who so took the form of a servant that he did not lose the form of God, [[p. 423]] of whom it was said: *He it is who baptizes*. Accordingly, whatever man is the minister of his baptism, whatever burden he bears, it is not that man, but he upon whom the dove descended — he it is who baptizes. But so great an absurdity follows those men who think empty things, that they find no way to escape it. For when they confess that baptism is valid and true when some criminal, whose crimes are hidden, baptizes among them, we say to them: ‘Who then baptizes?’ And they have nothing to answer but: ‘God’ — for they cannot say that an adulterous man sanctifies anyone. To whom we answer: ‘If, then, when a manifestly righteous man baptizes, he himself sanctifies, but when a secretly wicked man baptizes, then it is not he but God who sanctifies, those who are baptized ought to wish to be baptized by secretly evil men rather than by manifestly good ones; for God sanctifies them far better than any righteous man does. But if it is absurd that anyone to be baptized should wish to be baptized by a hidden adulterer rather than by a manifest chaste man, then it certainly remains that, whatever human minister has come to it, the baptism is valid for this reason: that he upon whom the dove descended, he himself baptizes.’